

Dead on Scene

There are very specific criteria for making the determination of “Dead on Scene” (DOS) or “Dead on Arrival” (DOA). With the exception of patients with DNR/POLST orders, only patients who are apneic (not breathing) AND pulseless AND with one or more of the following criteria should be considered “DOA” and resuscitation should be withheld:

- Rigor mortis of the trunk and/or extremities (jaw stiffness alone does not signify rigor mortis)
- Livor mortis (Dependent Lividity)
- Decapitation
- Incineration
- Decomposition

If bystanders or other responders have begun resuscitative efforts and the patient meets the above criteria, agency personnel should tactfully point out the DOA criteria and stop all resuscitation.

The absence of vital signs in patients meeting at least one of the above criteria shall be confirmed by hands-on palpitation. If no monitor and paramedic are available, the EMT, AEMT, or paramedic shall attach the patient to an AED to confirm no shockable rhythm and again ensure the absence of a pulse. IF there are any questions about absence of pulse, respirations, or specific DOA criteria, resuscitation shall be started immediately.

Document the time the absence of vital signs was determined.

If any question or conflict exists about the DOA status of a patient, agency personnel shall start basic CPR and contact Medical Control as possible.